

Casual play changes the picture.

A like-for-like three-year comparison of games against the official Maia 1, 5, and 9 Lichess accounts—same bots, same last-move window, separate rated and casual exports.

2,040,728 casual games	1,425,567 rated games	58.9% casual share of combined games
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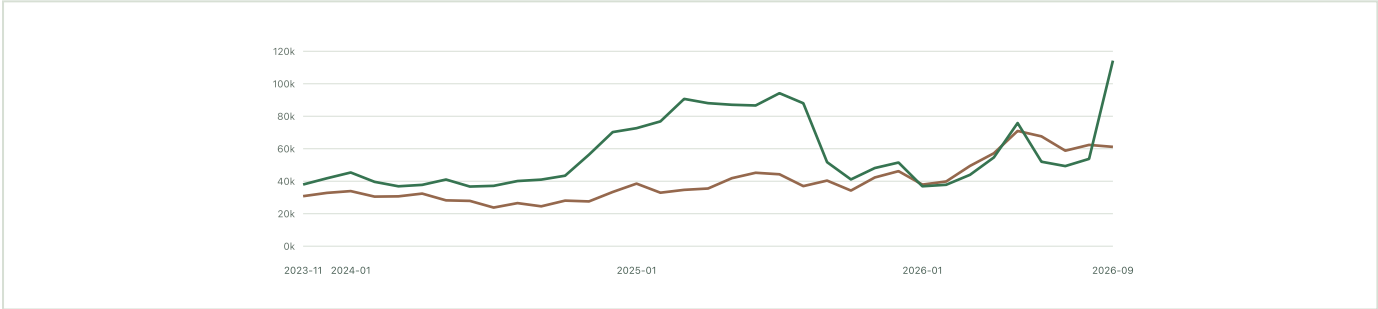
One bot-game entry is a game attached to one Maia account. No game ID occurs in both exports or under two bots in this window, so entry counts equal unique games. Scope: last recorded move from 2023-10-04 00:00 UTC through before 2026-10-04 09:00 UTC. No moves/PGNs were collected.

01 / GROWTH

Both formats grew; rated grew faster.

Across the first and last complete 12-month periods, casual play changed by **+37.7%** (478,675 → 659,197); rated play changed by **+79.4%** (350,152 → 628,041). Casual's share of combined games fell from **57.8%** to **51.2%**. These are counts, not a measure of unique people.

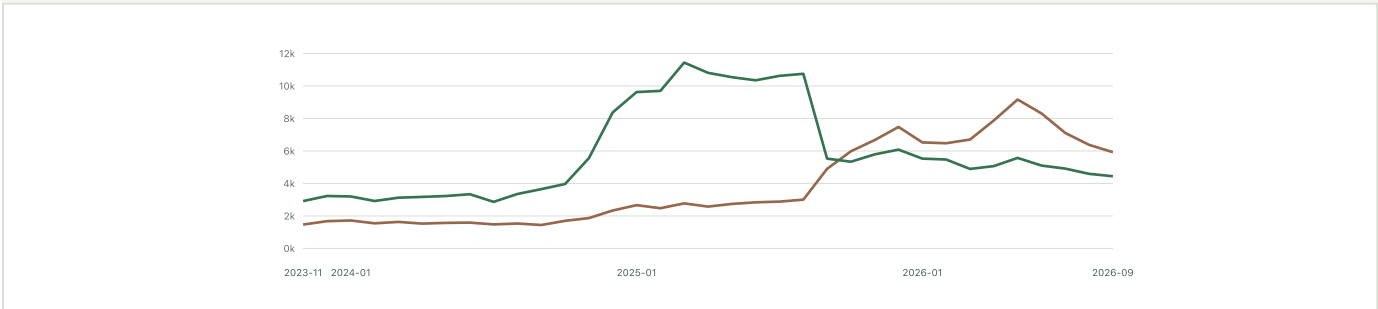
Rated Casual



Complete UTC months only, November 2023–September 2026. Partial October 2023 and October 2026 are excluded. Monthly values are bot-game entries; here they also equal unique games.

September's casual spike is concentrated. Public account [scissorsharpness](#) recorded 63,504 casual games that month—55.6% of all casual September games, mostly Maia 1 at 1+0. Without this one account, September has 50,729 casual games versus 53,754 in August; last-year casual growth would be +24.4% rather than +37.7%. This is a sensitivity check, not a judgment about the account.

Monthly active opposing accounts



Distinct public handles observed in each UTC month, separately by format. The same account can appear in multiple months and both formats. September 2026 had 4,446 casual accounts versus 4,594 in August.

► Show all 35 complete months

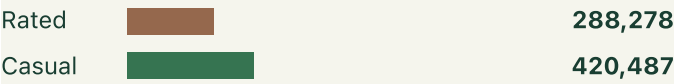
Casual play is not simply the rated pattern at larger scale.

Games by Maia bot

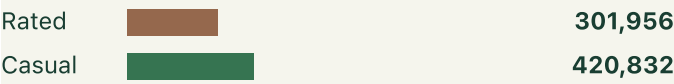
Maia 1



Maia 5



Maia 9



Games by Lichess speed category

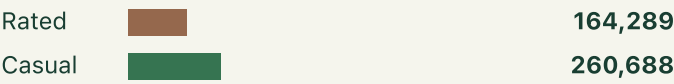
Rapid



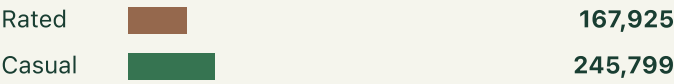
Blitz



Classical



Bullet



Most common exact clocks

Format	Clock	Games	Share of format
Rated	10+0	214,879	15.1%
Rated	5+3	142,986	10.0%
Rated	10+5	87,149	6.1%
Rated	3+2	67,850	4.8%
Rated	15+10	66,378	4.7%
Casual	10+0	339,890	16.7%
Casual	5+3	190,489	9.3%
Casual	10+5	138,747	6.8%
Casual	1+0	128,979	6.3%
Casual	15+10	119,119	5.8%

Clock format is starting minutes + increment seconds. Counts describe chosen settings, not playing strength. The September account contributed 63,504 of the casual 1+0 games, so that clock's raw ranking is unusually sensitive to one account.

Account mix matters more than a raw win-rate comparison.

128,628 opposing casual accounts	93,020 opposing rated accounts	23,542 accounts found in both exports
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105,086 handles appear only in casual games in this window; 69,478 appear only in rated games. Handles are public Lichess account IDs, not verified unique people.

Opponent Lichess rating

Per game	casual 1,499 · rated 1,515
Per account	casual 1,458 · rated 1,438

Game-weighted means give frequent players more influence. Account-weighted means first average each handle's recorded ratings, then weight handles equally. These are Lichess ratings, not FIDE Elo.

Maia wins among decisive games

Bot	Rated	Casual
Maia 1	56.7%	70.6%
Maia 5	52.5%	66.6%
Maia 9	54.9%	66.3%

Excludes games with no winning side. Rating, clock, opponent selection, and repeated players differ; these percentages do not isolate the effect of the rated setting.

The same players often use both formats, but a simple casual-versus-rated comparison is observational. It cannot show that a format causes improvement or changes Maia's playing strength.

Rebuild the comparison from the published metadata.

The [casual export](#) contains all 2,040,728 collected metadata rows in 12 compressed bot/year files. The [rated export](#) contains 1,425,567 rows. Both manifests include SHA-256 checksums, row counts, and field definitions. Run `python3 scripts/build_casual_comparison.py` at the repository root to recheck every shard and regenerate this page and the [aggregate JSON](#).

Exports include game IDs, public handles where available, timestamps, results, speed, clock, opening labels, and recorded ratings. They do not include moves, PGNs, chat, or private identity mappings. The collection used date splitting below Lichess's observed response cap, then verified gap-free query-date coverage and in-scope last-move timestamps. A seven-day game-start lookback reduces—but cannot prove away—the possibility of an unusually long game that began earlier and finished inside the study window.

Source: [Lichess user-game export](#). The repository MIT license covers original code and report writing, not Lichess or player-originated game data. This is independent fan research, not an official Lichess/Maia publication.

Supplement to [How people play the Maia bots on Lichess](#). Findings are descriptive and limited to the fixed three-year study window.